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OR, THE

NUMERALS OF SCRIPTURE

A PROOF OF INSPIRATION.

A FREE INQUIRY.

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He created Wisdom, and saw her, and *numbered* her, and poured her upon all His works. Why else is He styled PALMONI (Dan. viii, 13), which is rendered in the margin of our English Bibles, *The Numberer of Secrets, or the Wonderful Numberer?*—BIBLIOTHECA BIBLICA, iv, p. 8.

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Ὁ Θεὸς μάλιστα πάντων γεωμετρεῖ.

"He created Wisdom, and saw her, and *numbered* her, and poured her upon all His works."—Ecclus. i, 9.

"Thou hast ordered all things in measure, and *number*, and weight."—Wisdom xi, 30.

"Of His understanding there is no *number*."—Ps. cxlvii, 5.

"Est autem, et præter illam alia quam nos attulimus, nova per numeros philosophandi institutio, antiqua illa quidem, et à priscis Theologis, a Pythagora præsertim . . . . prioribusque Platonicis observata: sed quæ hac tempestate, ut præclara alia, posteriorum incuria sic exolevit, ut vix vestigia ipsius ulla reperiantur."—Johan. Picus de Mirandula, quoted in *Bibliothec. Biblic.* iv, p. 9.

PREFACE.

THIS is called "a *free* Inquiry," because it is strictly such: the subject with which it deals being entirely an open question, and the investigation of it being conducted with all due deference (I trust) to prejudices which it may disturb, but without any appeal to *mere* authority, whether of the early Church or the modern.

In some parts of the work the ground has been broken by others, and I have of course availed myself of the advantage of their labors. The chronology, for example, has been learnedly explored by Browne, in his *Ordo Sæclorum*, a book frequently referred to in the course of this Inquiry. But I have not simply followed Browne. A mistake of his, in one important point, led me to work out the whole scheme *de novo et ab ovo.* The result has been that, with the exception of this one point, I find my effort to harmonize in the main with his, and so far as the principle is concerned to be more than corroborative of his remarkable conclusions.

In that part of the work which will be the newest to most readers, and in which I may have to entreat them to "strike, but hear," the leading idea is one familiar to the early Church. It does not appear, however, that it was ever subjected to a rigorous scientific examination.

As to the connection between these parts, the application of mystic numbers as a key to sacred dates, I do not know whether any one has been before me. The famous Mirandula professed to have found the secret of Spiritual Arithmetic: but what he made of the subject, or whether he put his discoveries to the severe proof of connecting them with Chronology, I have not been able to ascertain.

Hoping the effort may be useful, at least in calling attention to an interesting subject, I submit it to the judgment of the candid and thoughtful reader.

M. Mahan.

General Theological Seminary, N. Y.,
June 9th, 1863.

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PALMONI;

OR,

THE NUMERALS OF SCRIPTURE.

CHAPTER I.

GENERAL VIEW OF THE SUBJECT.

As the subject of this Inquiry is one that will be new to most readers, and as the principal drift of it will not appear all at once, it seems proper to state beforehand, what are some of the results which may be expected from it. And this I will do in a hypothetical form.

Suppose it had been our fortune to alight on some valuable historical documents of the olden time; suppose these documents, being examined, were found to contain a very precise Chronology, covering a period of thousands of years, and interspersed with lively narratives of the most interesting character; suppose further, that the contents of these documents were of a kind to provoke much discussion, to excite curiosity, to satisfy in part, and in part to baffle, that eager desire of knowledge which is natural to man: we can readily

imagine, in such a case, what pains would be taken to make out with precision the Record thus brought before us, to sum up its peculiarities, to ascertain, if possible, the principle on which it was constructed.

Now the Bible is such a collection of ancient documents. It contains a Chronology such as has been described. Yet, strange to say, the effort to draw out that Chronology as a whole, to present it honestly as it is, and to examine and account for its characteristic features, is even to this day almost a new thing. There have been plenty of attempts to *amend* the Chronology of the Bible. To set it forth symmetrically, in its own proper guise, has been aimed at by few, and has never perhaps been achieved with entire success by any.*

Suppose further, that, an honest effort being made to give this Chronology as it is, it should thereupon appear to abound in curious *parallelisms*, in strange *coincidences*, in *symmetries* of the most remarkable and rhythmical description. Suppose it should be marked in every part by the recurrence of certain mystical terms of years, not in a random way, but at intervals and in proportions elaborately exact. Suppose, in short, that this Chronology should prove to be constructed on a system. Suppose, finally, that a key to this system should appear in certain numerals, such as Five, Seven, Eight, Thirteen, and the like, which can be shown, by a rigorous induction and by scientific tests, to have a definite *spiritual* meaning, over and above their arithmetical value.

* Browne's *Ordo Sæclorum* is the nearest approach to a success; but in one or two points, as I expect to show, he has substituted conjecture for *facts*, preferring epochs of his own to those given him in Scripture.

In such a case, the proof of *Design* in the peculiarities of the Numerals of Scripture would be of such a character as no one could candidly disregard: the notion of chance coincidences would be absolutely excluded.

But suppose further, that the system thus discovered should be *latent*, in the same sense that the laws of nature are latent: in other words, that it should be obvious enough when once pointed out, but of a character to elude casual observation, and discoverable only on the application of certain experimental tests. Suppose *one* key to this system should be found in two or three *seemingly casual* utterances of the New Testament; and *another* key in two or three well-known dates of ordinary history. Suppose, generally, that its secret should lie, like the secret of Samson's strength, in those parts of Holy Scripture which critics are apt to consider a fair subject for their scissors, which being "unimportant," they can clip and pare at pleasure: in the *obiter dicta*, as such passages are learnedly called, or in texts "manifestly corrupt," or "totally irreconcilable," or branded with any other of those phrases by which interpreters put the blame of their own stupidity upon the "sure word" of God.

In such a case, there would be decided evidence of a *supernatural* Design in the Numerals of Scripture.

Suppose, finally, that the system should be found not only consistent with itself, but in harmony with the general scheme of nature and revelation; that it should be found to ramify into the *minutiæ* of Scripture names and Scripture types, and into the dates connected with those names and the numbers connected with those types, and should seem to run through the whole of

the sacred Text from Genesis to Revelation, in fibres as minute but as organic as the capillaries of the human body; nay, should occasionally take hold of things outside of Scripture times, and, overleaping hundreds of years between, should seize upon ordinary history *precisely at those points*, where, *supposing the system to be divine*, *it might be expected* to seize on it.

The supposition may seem extravagant. And I do not profess to be able to make it good to the utmost. Supposing, however, that it can be proved even in part, and that in such instances as are capable of being *tested mathematically* it should be shown to hold true, then the evidence of a *supernatural element* in Scripture, of a supernatural life pervading its organism, would not at all fall short of a scientific demonstration.

The present Inquiry is an effort in that direction. It does not pretend, however, to cover the whole ground. It is an examination of *one little corner* of a vast field of inquiry: a field more familiar to the early Church than to Christians of our times—the great and fertile field of the Symbolism of Scripture.

The Inquiry divides into three parts, which, as originally undertaken, were three separate investigations, begun at different times and from different motives, with no idea when they were begun that they would be found to be connected.

The first is merely a summary of the Six Epochs, and Six Days of Preparation for Christ's Kingdom: an arrangement adopted by the writer many years ago, partly for its convenience, and partly for the beautiful analogy it presents to the Six Days of Creation.

The second is a simple summing up of the dates and periods given in the Hebrew Scriptures. This was un-

dertaken with a view to correct two or three obvious errors in Browne's *Ordo Sæclorum*, and with an idea that, the mistakes of this ingenious author being corrected, the *symmetries* which he points out, would prove to be delusive. The result, however, was entirely the opposite. Few of the "parallelisms" were touched by the correction: while many, not noticed by Browne and *of a more systematic character* than those which he has noticed, were brought out to view. His mistakes, in fact, conceal the most beautiful of the parallels: and though he gives instances enough to show that there is something very remarkable in the sacred "times and seasons," yet there are hardly enough to prove the principle that seems to pervade the entire scheme.* In the table of dates, as corrected in the present work, the general plan comes out so clearly, that it may be taken in at a glance.

The third branch of the Inquiry is a curious, and, I fear, may be thought a rather frivolous one. It is an examination into a point familiar to the early Church, and not without interest to some of our "matter-of-fact" moderns.† It began with an attempt to ascertain how far the strange "coincidences" connected with the so-called *Dominical Number*, *Eight*, are capable of rigid proof, or are merely oddities of that kind which may amuse an idle moment, but from a more serious point of view are unworthy of regard. Having investigated *Eight*, I was led on to take up *Seven*, with the

* Of these mistakes, however, there is only one that affects the general results. The others balance one another, and are comparatively unimportant.

† See Wordsworth's "New Testament," *Notes* on 1 Peter iii, 21; 2 Pet. ii, 5; Luke xxiv, 1; Matt. x, 2; John xxi, 11.

same object in view. This brought me to the examination of some other "sacred" numbers. I have not given *all* the results of this inquiry. Those that I have given, however, are fair samples of the rest, and may serve to show, if nothing more, that the early Fathers had some excuse for their devotion to this curious branch of study.

It was after I had made some progress in the third of these inquiries, that I noticed how intimately they were connected: how admirably the Table of Dates fell in with the scheme of Days and Epochs, and what a light the "sacred Numbers" shed on the peculiarities of the Table of Dates.

With these remarks, I invite the reader to accompany me on a short excursion into this region of sacred Chronology. It is not as dry a field as most people imagine. There are flowers and fruits in it. And though the "flowers" may be partly of that kind which a learned and devout fancy can create at pleasure, yet many of them *may* be, and some of them doubtless are, of His handiwork who orders the "times and the seasons," Who numbers the very hairs upon our heads, Who determines man's days and the number of his months,* and Who may intentionally have clothed the otherwise dry details of Time's progress with something appealing to the imagination, out of that same abounding goodness which furnishes springs in the desert, or hangs the delicate and ethereal harebell upon the face of the bare rock.

And I may say in conclusion, that the difficulties of the inquiry are less than might be supposed. An English Bible and Concordance, a moderate facility in

* Job. xiv, 5.